12

Continued Dictatorship and Lost Hope, 1990–2007

Following the electoral fiasco of 1990, the main goal of the military was to maintain the status quo and, as quickly as possible, remove the National League for Democracy (NLD) and their marquee leader out of the public spotlight. Over the next two decades, the government would engage in a constant battle in an attempt to maintain a façade of legitimacy based on the obligation of maintaining law and order with the intention of suppressing the rightfully elected leaders of the country. This battle would spill over into nearly every aspect of the public and private realm. The economic, social, cultural, and international policies of Myanmar would be impacted by this never-ending contest.

SLORC TIGHTENS GRIP

One interesting decision made by the regime in the pre-election period was to announce the name change to the country, towns, and population. In mid October 1988, the ruling State Law and Order Restoration Council (SLORC) enacted the “Law on the Substitution of Terms.” The “Socialist Republic of the Union of Burma” was changed to “Union of Burma” as well as additional titles and terms. During May and June of 1989, SLORC went a step further and decided to change the name of the country to the Union of Myanmar. The rationale was that the name Burma carried with it colonial connotations and by going back to what SLORC thought was the original “proper” pronunciation, “Myanmar,” the vestiges of colonial would be removed.

SLORC remained vague concerning the future political situation in Myanmar. By 1992, meetings were held with the representatives of the